



**BROAD VISION** Azad Moopen, Founder & Chairman of Aster DM Healthcare, says there is a big opportunity in India considering its population

## HEALTHCARE

# Marching North

After selling its Gulf business, Aster DM Healthcare is doubling down on India, and is looking to expand in the North

BY NEETU CHANDRA SHARMA

► **AFTER GLOBAL HOSPITAL** chain Aster DM Healthcare separated its India and GCC (Gulf Co-operation Council) businesses, it is looking to double down on the Indian market and plans now to expand into the north Indian market. The hospital chain's presence is currently concentrated in south India, especially Kerala—six of its 19 Indian hospitals are located in the state.

The company sees a substantial demand-supply gap in India's healthcare sector, thanks in part to the country's population, estimated at more than 1.4 billion. "In India, there exists a substantial demand-supply gap, particularly pronounced in the North and Northeast regions. The shortage of hospital beds is evident, with the organised sector having less than 100,000 beds,

**AT PRESENT, ASTER HAS 19 HOSPITALS IN INDIA, AND SIX OF THESE ARE LOCATED IN KERALA**

while the actual requirement is estimated to be ten times higher," Dr Azad Moopen, Founder & Chairman of Aster DM Healthcare, tells *BT*.

The demand, Moopen believes, has been amplified by government initiatives like the Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (PM-JAY), a national health insurance scheme, and various health schemes of states, covering individuals across income groups. "People are increasingly seeking high-quality tertiary and quaternary care closer to home and are willing to pay for it, either in cash or through insurance," Moopen says.

The reorientation of Aster DM Healthcare, which in FY22-23 posted an annual turnover of ₹11,933 crore, is the result of a windfall of